crowds gathered in Tiananmen Square in Beijing to honour Zhou. They openly criticized the Gang of Four, and indirectly, therefore, even Mao himself. The police, and later, security forces, intervened in this rare show of unauthorized public discontent.

Then came Mao's turn. He died on 9 September of the same year. His last public appearance had been on 27 May, when he had received the visiting Pakistani Prime Minister Zulfikar Ali Bhutto. After the death of the old Chairman, his official portrait was hung on the wall of the main gate at Tiananmen with a banner reading 'Carry on the cause left by Chairman Mao and carry on the cause of proletarian revolution to the end'.[60]

Inevitably, an intense power struggle followed the death of the old Chairman—and it was time for Deng to make his final comeback. Mao had appointed a loyal follower, Hua Guofeng, as his successor, but he was weak and unable to keep the fragmented CCP together. The first to come under attack was the Gang of Four. Before the end of the year, they were purged, arrested, and later put on trial.

Deng who had been in and out of power since the Cultural Revolution, was finally the new strongman by 1980. Hua was replaced by Zhao Ziyang as premier in 1980 and as CCP chief by Hu Yaobang the following year. Both were Deng supporters. Hu exonerated over three million people who had suffered during the Cultural Revolution. Zhao was one of the driving forces behind the new, more open economic policies that were launched in the early 1980s. The Mao era with its rigid ideologies and fanatical policies seemed to be over.

The return of Deng also heralded a new era in China's foreign policy. The Three Worlds concept was still very much alive, but now with a different tone and emphasis. 'China, though a big country, has never sought a special position in the third world. It is not the leader of the third world, not now and never will it be, because such a thing runs counter to the principles of China's relations with foreign countries.'[61] And China now sought friendly relations with as many foreign countries as possible. This was a definite departure from Mao's Three World theory, according to which friendly relations could be upheld even with capitalist nations if the common enemy was the Soviet Union, but where 'the people of the world support each other in their just struggles[62]…the peoples of all countries are